

# SENATE . . . . . No. 426

## The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

PRESENTED BY:

***Jacob R. Oliveira***

*To the Honorable Senate and House of Representatives of the Commonwealth of Massachusetts in General Court assembled:*

The undersigned legislators and/or citizens respectfully petition for the adoption of the accompanying bill:

An Act to ensure that all students are prepared for future success.

PETITION OF:

| NAME:                      | DISTRICT/ADDRESS:                                 |                  |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <i>Jacob R. Oliveira</i>   | <i>Hampden, Hampshire and Worcester</i>           |                  |
| <i>Vanna Howard</i>        | <i>17th Middlesex</i>                             | <i>1/30/2025</i> |
| <i>Joanne M. Comerford</i> | <i>Hampshire, Franklin and Worcester</i>          | <i>1/31/2025</i> |
| <i>Michael D. Brady</i>    | <i>Second Plymouth and Norfolk</i>                | <i>1/31/2025</i> |
| <i>James K. Hawkins</i>    | <i>2nd Bristol</i>                                | <i>2/12/2025</i> |
| <i>James B. Eldridge</i>   | <i>Middlesex and Worcester</i>                    | <i>3/3/2025</i>  |
| <i>Paul W. Mark</i>        | <i>Berkshire, Hampden, Franklin and Hampshire</i> | <i>3/31/2025</i> |
| <i>Pavel M. Payano</i>     | <i>First Essex</i>                                | <i>7/7/2025</i>  |
| <i>Nick Collins</i>        | <i>First Suffolk</i>                              | <i>1/21/2026</i> |

# SENATE . . . . . No. 426

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By Mr. Oliveira, a petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 426) of Jacob R. Oliveira, Vanna Howard, Joanne M. Comerford, Michael D. Brady and other members of the General Court for legislation to ensure that all students are prepared for future success. Education.

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## The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

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In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court  
(2025-2026)  
\_\_\_\_\_

An Act to ensure that all students are prepared for future success.

*Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:*

1           SECTION 1. Chapter 69 of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting after  
2 section 37 the following section:-

3           Section 38. MassCore

4           (a) The department shall, in collaboration with the MassCore advisory council established  
5 pursuant to subsection (d) and subject to the approval of the board, develop, implement and  
6 administer a statewide program of study, to be known as MassCore, to align high school courses  
7 with college and workforce expectations and to ensure that all students are prepared to be  
8 knowledgeable, empowered and civically engaged adults who can thrive upon high school  
9 graduation and throughout their lives. MassCore shall, except as otherwise herein provided, be a  
10 required program of study for all high school students in the commonwealth beginning with  
11 students entering ninth grade in the 2027-2028 school year.

(b) MassCore shall consist of four units of English, four units of mathematics, three units of a lab-based science, three units of history, two units of the same world language, one unit of the arts and five additional core elective courses; provided, however, that the MassCore program of study may be amended upon a joint recommendation to the board by the department and the MassCore advisory council and subject to the approval of the board.

All MassCore courses shall be aligned with the appropriate grade-level standards in the Massachusetts curriculum frameworks. School districts and educators shall have flexibility and professional autonomy in selecting curriculum and in designing and administering teaching and learning in line with the appropriate grade-level standards.

(c) The department shall, in collaboration with the MassCore advisory council and subject to the approval of the board, develop and promulgate regulations governing the implementation, administration and enforcement of this section, which shall include, but not be limited to: (i) creating a waiver process by which certain student subgroups, including, but not limited to, multilingual learners, students with disabilities and students who are newly enrolled in a public school in the commonwealth may be exempt from some or all of the MassCore requirements; (ii) creating a process by which school districts may, subject to approval by the department, award high school credit in compliance with this section for MassCore-equivalent courses taken in middle school; (iii) creating a process by which school districts may receive a temporary waiver of the requirements of this section due to a demonstrated hardship; (iv) ensuring flexibility for students in selecting courses that satisfy the MassCore requirements, including within subject areas, and ensuring flexibility in meeting the MassCore requirements for students enrolled in state-approved career and technical education programs; (v) establishing a reporting process for school districts to demonstrate compliance with the MassCore

requirements; and (vi) establishing a process for recommending changes or updates to MassCore that shall include public input.

Said regulations shall be developed using a transparent and inclusive process that meaningfully engages students, educators, administrators, parents and other stakeholders, particularly those from historically marginalized and underserved communities and populations. In developing said regulations, the department and the MassCore advisory council shall jointly convene not less than 2 public meetings across the commonwealth, shall create and administer a statewide survey open to members of the public and available in multiple languages, and may hold additional hearings and other forums as necessary.

(d) There shall be a MassCore advisory council to collaborate with and advise the department on all matters related to MassCore and the implementation of this section. The advisory council shall consist of: 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Teachers Association; 1 member who shall be appointed by the American Federation of Teachers, Massachusetts; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Association of School Superintendents, Inc.; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Association of School Committees, Inc.; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Parent Teachers Association; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Association of Regional Schools; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Association of Vocational Administrators Inc.; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts School Counselors Association; 1 member who shall be a high school student appointed by the Massachusetts Association of Student Representatives; 1 member who shall be appointed by the NAACP; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Immigrant and Refugee Advocacy Coalition; 1 member who shall be appointed by Citizens for Public

Schools; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Advocates for Children; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Consortium for Innovative Education Assessment; and 1 member who shall be a researcher from a public university in the commonwealth with expertise in the area of public elementary and secondary education, selected by the members of the advisory council.

The advisory council shall determine the means of conducting its work and shall meet as often as the members shall determine. The department and the advisory council shall meet at least quarterly.

(e) By December 31, 2025, school districts shall report to the department on their capacity to comply with this section. The report shall be submitted in a form and manner prescribed by the department and shall include, but not be limited to, whether a district is already in compliance with the course requirements of this section and, for those districts not already in compliance, an estimate of additional financial costs directly related to coming into compliance and whether such costs will create a demonstrated financial hardship for the school district including, but not limited to, by directly resulting in cuts to existing school staff, courses or programs.

By February 1, 2026, the department shall submit to the general court a request for an appropriation to those school districts with a demonstrated financial hardship, as determined by the department, for the total costs associated with coming into compliance with the requirements of this section. The MassCore course and program requirements in this section shall not be in effect for students in said school districts until such a time that said appropriation is made to said school districts.

(f) Nothing in this section shall be construed as prohibiting a school district from implementing MassCore prior to the 2027-2028 school year or from implementing course or unit requirements for students that exceed the requirements of MassCore.

SECTION 2. (a) There shall be a special commission to study and make recommendations for more authentic and accurate methods of assessing students in the commonwealth. The commission shall examine: (i) the requirements of the Every Student Succeeds Act of 2015, codified at 20 U.S.C. § 6301 et. seq., and potential waivers; (ii) alternative assessment measures in place or being considered nationwide; and (iii) research data on the knowledge and skills that parents, elementary and secondary educators, higher education educators, and business leaders want students to have upon high school graduation.

Regarding the assessment of students, the special commission shall consider assessments other than conventional methods, including, but not limited to: work samples, capstone, service learning or other projects, portfolios, performance assessments and other authentic and direct gauges of student performance that encourage effective instruction, use strategies for avoiding racial and ethnic biases, and recognize the strengths of all students.

The commission shall recommend strategies for assessing students that comply with current federal law. The commission may also make recommendations for changes in or waivers from federal law that would facilitate the implementation of effective assessment strategies.

(b) The commission shall consist of: 1 member who shall be appointed by the president of the senate, who shall serve as co-chair; 1 member who shall be appointed by the speaker of the house of representatives, who shall serve as co-chair; 1 member who shall be appointed by the minority leader of the senate; 1 member who shall be appointed by the minority leader of the

102 house of representatives; the secretary of education, or a designee; the commissioner of  
103 elementary and secondary education, or a designee; 1 member who shall be appointed by the  
104 Massachusetts Association of School Committees, Inc.; 1 member who shall be appointed by the  
105 Massachusetts Teachers Association; 1 member who shall be appointed by the American  
106 Federation of Teachers, Massachusetts; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts  
107 Association of School Superintendents, Inc.; 1 member who shall be appointed by the  
108 Massachusetts Association of Regional Schools; 1 member who shall be appointed by the  
109 Massachusetts Association of Vocational Administrators Inc.; 1 member who shall be appointed  
110 by the Massachusetts Education Justice Alliance; 1 member who shall be appointed by Citizens  
111 for Public Schools; 1 member who shall be appointed by the NAACP; 1 member who shall be  
112 appointed by the Massachusetts Immigrant and Refugee Advocacy Coalition; 1 member who  
113 shall be appointed by Multicultural Education, Training, and Advocacy, Inc; 2 members who  
114 shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Consortium for Innovative Education Assessment, 1 of  
115 whom shall be a high school student attending a public high school in the consortium; 1 member  
116 who shall be a high school student appointed by Youth SOL; 1 member who shall be a high  
117 school student appointed by the Massachusetts Association of Student Representatives; 1  
118 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts School Counselors Association; 1 member  
119 who shall be appointed by the Black Educators Alliance of Massachusetts; 1 member who shall  
120 be appointed by the Massachusetts Asian American Educators Association; 1 member who shall  
121 be appointed by the Gaston Institute for Latino Community Development and Public Policy of  
122 the University of Massachusetts Boston; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts  
123 Advocates for Children; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Organization of  
124 Educational Collaboratives; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Massachusetts Parent

125 Teachers Association; 1 member who shall be appointed by the Center for Law and Education; 1  
126 member who shall be appointed by the Center for Antiracist Research at Boston University; 1  
127 member who shall be appointed by the Rural Policy Advisory Commission; 1 member who shall  
128 be appointed by GLSEN Massachusetts; and 1 member who shall be a researcher from a public  
129 university in the commonwealth with expertise in the area of assessment, selected jointly by the  
130 members of the commission. Members shall not receive compensation for their services but may  
131 receive reimbursement for reasonable expenses incurred in carrying out their responsibilities as  
132 members of the commission. The commissioner of elementary and secondary education shall  
133 furnish reasonable staff and other support for the work of the commission.

134 (c) When conducting its work and issuing its recommendations, the commission shall use  
135 a transparent and inclusive process that meaningfully engages students, educators,  
136 administrators, parents and other stakeholders, particularly those from historically marginalized  
137 and underserved communities and populations. The commission shall hold not less than 5 public  
138 meetings across the regions of the commonwealth, shall create and administer a statewide survey  
139 open to members of the public and available in multiple languages, and may hold additional  
140 hearings and other forums as necessary. The commission shall file its report and  
141 recommendations with the clerks of the senate and the house of representatives and the chairs of  
142 the joint committee on education not later than August 31, 2026.